3.1 The Election of 1860

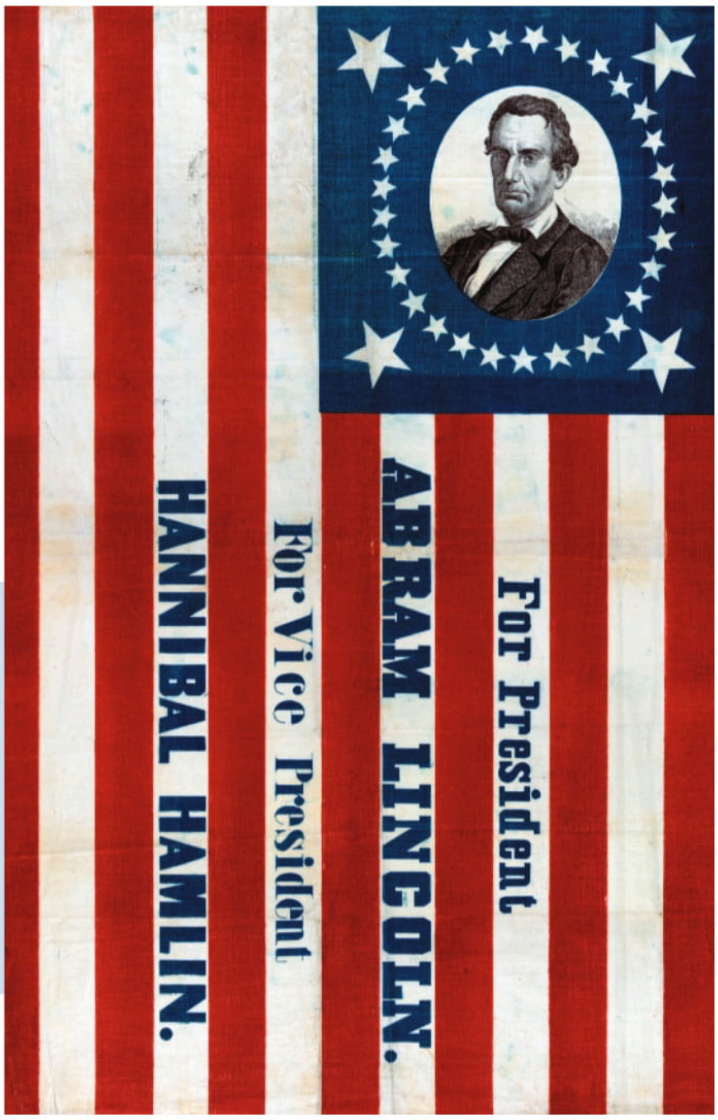
Say you belong to a club and two groups within it often disagree. Should they try to work things out? Or should one group break away and form a new club? Maybe it depends on whether they're into politics.

MAIN IDEA The growing divide between the North and the South had a strong impact on the 1860 presidential election.

POLITICAL PARTIES BREAK APART

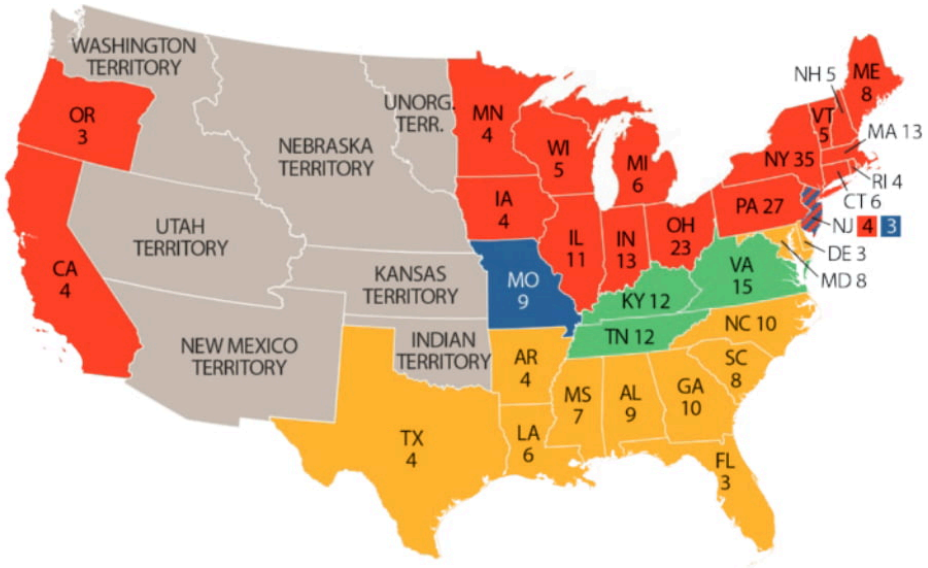
"Bleeding Kansas," the Dred Scott decision, John Brown's raid at Harpers Ferry: each of these developments had left the United States more divided over slavery. The Democratic Party found it harder to hold itself together as tensions grew between its powerful southern faction, or group, and its smaller northern faction. When the two factions could not agree on a candidate for the 1860 presidential election, the party split in two. Northern Democrats nominated Stephen Douglas of Illinois, and southern Democrats nominated **John Breckinridge** of Kentucky.

Around this same time, a group of former Whigs and Know-Nothings founded the conservative **Constitutional Union Party**. It appealed to people who believed that preserving the Union and protecting the Constitution outweighed concerns about slavery. For the election, **Unionists**, as members of the Constitutional Union Party were called, sought a compromise candidate who could appeal to both northerners and southerners. They chose John Bell, a highly regarded former U.S. senator from Tennessee.



Lincoln Campaign Banner
Lincoln's running mate in the 1860 election was Hannibal Hamlin, a senator from Maine. In this cotton flag, Lincoln's first name is spelled "Abram," possibly to enable his name to appear larger. "Abram" is also the original spelling of the biblical Abraham. The portrait of Lincoln may have been printed sideways so the flag could be hung vertically.

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1860 Presidential Election

Lincoln, Republican

Electoral Vote: 180 votes, 59.4%

Popular Vote: 1,866,452 votes, 39.8%

Douglas, Northern Democrat

Electoral Vote: 12 votes, 3.9%

Popular Vote: 1,380,202 votes, 29.5%

Breckinridge, Southern Democrat

Electoral Vote: 72 votes, 23.8%

Popular Vote: 847,953 votes, 18.1%

Bell, Constitutional Unionist

Electoral Vote: 39 votes, 12.9%

Popular Vote: 590,901 votes, 12.6%

THE NOMINATION OF LINCOLN

In May 1860, Republicans gathered in Chicago, Illinois, for their national convention. Party strategists identified four states that would be key to winning the upcoming election: Illinois, Indiana, New Jersey, and Pennsylvania. The first three bordered southern states and were more moderate in their views about slavery than states farther north. The party decided to place its presidential hopes on a moderate from Illinois: Abraham Lincoln.

Born in a one-room log cabin, Lincoln grew up on frontier farms in Kentucky and Indiana. His mother died when he was just nine. Because the family was poor, they moved from place to place, struggling to survive. Young Lincoln developed a love of reading but had to work, so he received very little formal schooling. When Lincoln was 21, he moved with his family to Illinois. There, he taught himself law, built a thriving legal practice, and launched a successful political career. He served four terms in the Illinois state assembly and one term in the U.S. House of Representatives. He failed twice in bids for the U.S. Senate, but that didn't stop him from running for president in 1860.

In the presidential campaign, Lincoln did not try to win over southern voters, and Breckinridge spent little effort on the North. Southerners refused to consider Lincoln because they believed he was too antislavery, while northerners rejected Breckinridge's proslavery views. Bell focused his attention on like-minded Unionists in the states between the North and the South. Douglas, however, campaigned in both the North and the South, defending the Union and warning against voting along sectional lines. Because Bell and Douglas didn't propose enacting laws one way or the other on slavery, they were considered the moderate candidates.

When voters cast their ballots on election day, Lincoln won almost 40 percent of the popular vote, and he captured the electoral votes in every northern state except New Jersey, which he split with Douglas. Not surprisingly, he didn't win any electoral votes in the South. For the most part, voters cast their ballots along regional lines. The election proved they were tired of compromising. And for many southerners, the election also drew a line in the sand that they were not afraid to cross.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why were there two Democratic candidates in the 1860 election?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why might Abraham Lincoln's background have appealed to voters?
3. **INTERPRET MAPS** Why did winning just the northern states guarantee that Lincoln would secure the majority of electoral votes?

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